Report

Security Misconfiguration

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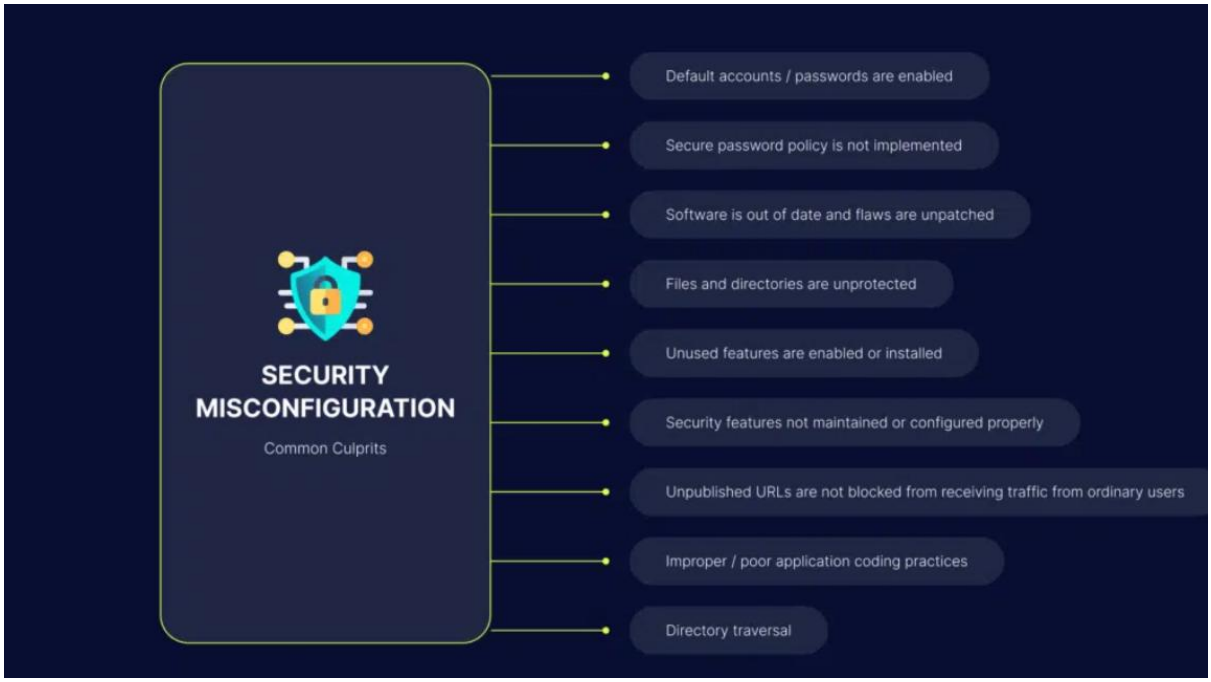
What is security misconfiguration?

A security misconfiguration occurs when system or application settings are incorrectly configured or essential configurations are missing. This leaves the system exposed to threats, allowing unauthorized access or exploitation. Misconfigurations can expose your organization to significant risk, whether it's an application, cloud infrastructure, or network setup.

Security misconfigurations are particularly widespread in cloud environments and are often cited as the top vulnerability in the cloud. With cloud platforms and services multiplying, it's essential to understand the risks misconfigurations pose and how they can be prevented.



Examples of Security Misconfigurations

Security misconfigurations come in many forms, and recognizing them can help you safeguard your systems. Here are eight common examples of security misconfigurations:

- **Unpatched Systems:** Failing to apply the latest security patches leaves your system vulnerable to known exploits, making it easier for attackers to infiltrate.

- **Default Account Settings:** Keeping default usernames and passwords unchanged gives hackers an easy entry point. These credentials are often widely known or easily guessed.
- **Unencrypted Files:** Storing sensitive data without encryption exposes it to unauthorized users, leading to potential data breaches or leaks.
- **Inadequate Access Controls:** Granting excessive permissions to users who don't need them increases the risk of internal threats or accidental data exposure.
- **Unprotected Files and Directories:** Publicly accessible files or directories can expose sensitive information, enabling attackers to exploit directory traversal vulnerabilities.
- **Web Application Misconfigurations:** Insecure configurations in web applications, such as improper authentication or exposing sensitive directories, can make them vulnerable to attacks like SQL injection or cross-site scripting.

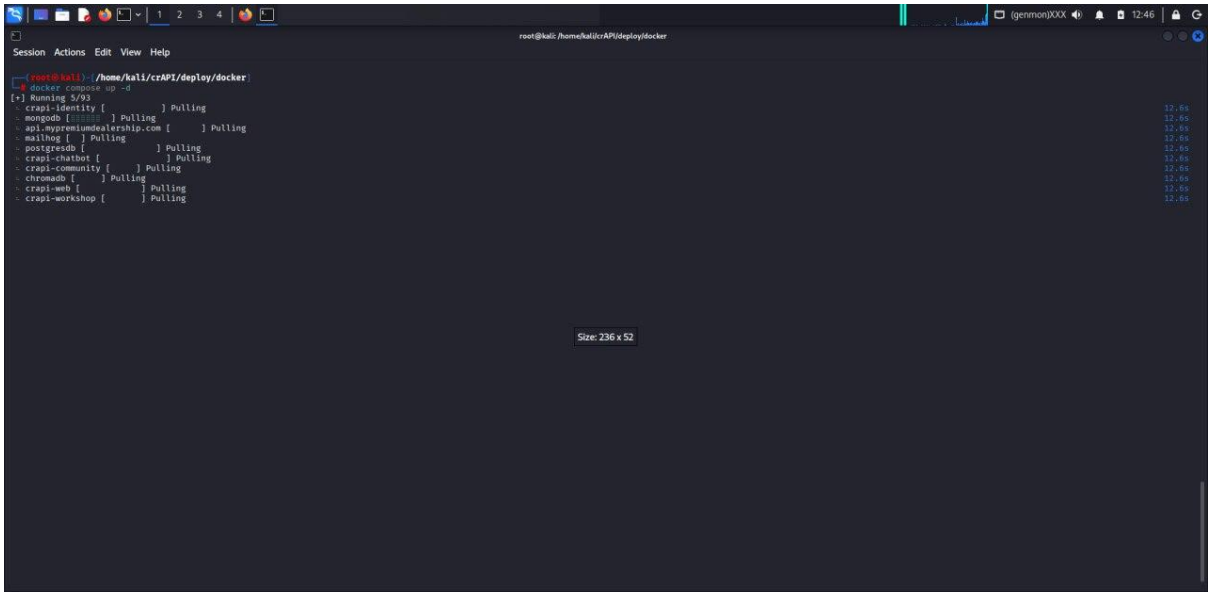
Why Do Security Misconfiguration Occur?

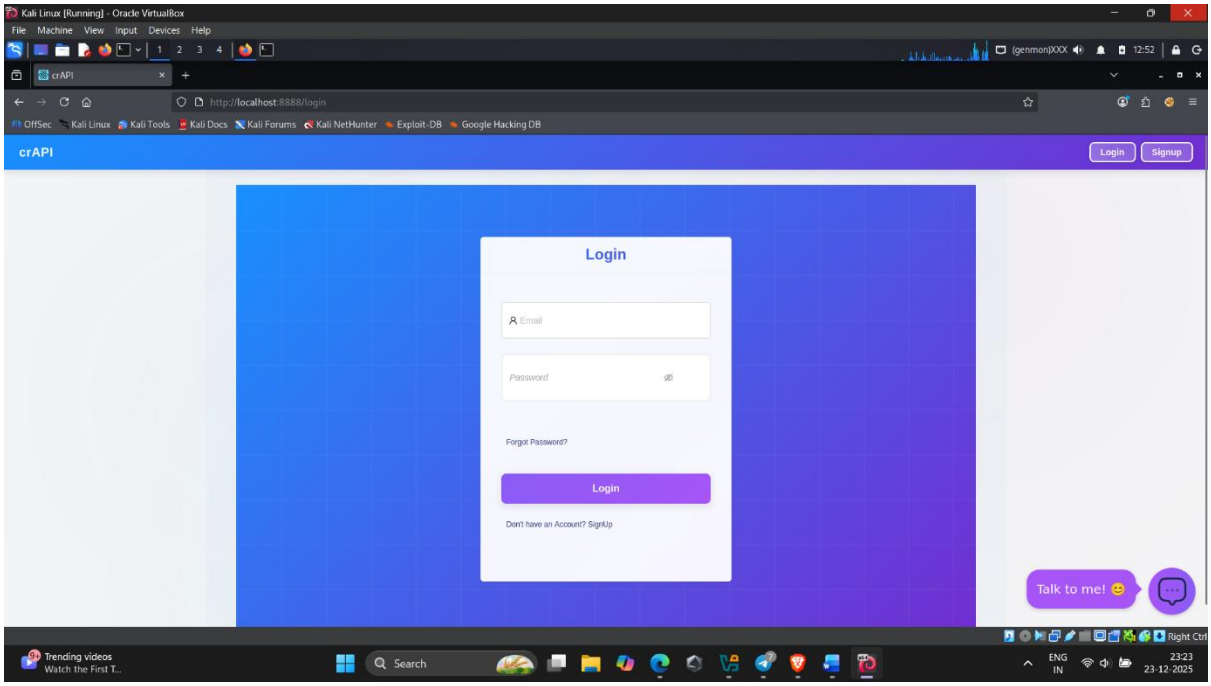
A misconfiguration may take place for a variety of reasons. Today's network infrastructures are intricate and continually changing organizations might overlook essential security settings, such as network equipment that could still have default configurations.

Even if an organization has secured configurations for its endpoints, you must still regularly audit security controls and configurations to identify configuration drift. New equipment is added to the network, systems change and patches are applied—all adding to misconfigurations.

Developers may develop network shares and firewall rules for ease, while building software keeping them unchanged. Sometimes, administrators permit configuration modifications for troubleshooting or testing purposes, but these don't return to the initial state.

Set up of crAPI:





Impact of Security Misconfigurations Attacks

Exposure without active attack

Security misconfigurations can expose sensitive data directly, allowing attackers to access information without exploiting any vulnerability.

Increased attack surface

The more code, services, or data exposed due to misconfiguration, the higher the risk of compromise and abuse.

Publicly accessible databases

Misconfigured database servers can be indexed by search engines, making sensitive data accessible through simple web searches.

Credential compromise

If exposed data includes admin credentials, attackers can escalate privileges and access other internal systems or servers.

Mass data leakage from storage services

Improper security settings on cloud storage or file servers can expose large volumes of sensitive and personal data to the public.

No visibility of data misuse

Once data is exposed due to misconfiguration, organizations usually cannot determine who accessed it or how it was used.

Directory listing exposure

Enabled directory listing allows attackers to browse application files, configurations, backups, and sensitive scripts.

Framework-based risks (e.g., CMS platforms)

Applications built on popular frameworks or CMS platforms (like WordPress) are especially vulnerable if default settings are not secured.

Application structure disclosure

Exposure of application structure helps attackers reverse-engineer, modify components, or identify further vulnerabilities.

Mobile application security challenges

Mobile apps weaken centralized control since business and presentation logic reside on user devices, increasing the risk of code tampering and analysis.

References:

https://owasp.org/Top10/2021/A05_2021-Security_Misconfiguration/

https://brightsec.com/blog/security-misconfiguration/